

Sentence Structure

MODEL

Sentence Structure



A Person Who Has Made a Difference: George Lucas

¹Filmmaker George Lucas has changed the film industry in many ways.

²He has written, directed, and produced some of the best-loved movies of our time.

³He has also made major contributions to modern film technology. ⁴At first, Lucas did not plan to become a filmmaker. ⁵His first dream was to become a race car driver. ⁶After a bad accident, however, he decided to go to college. ⁷In college, Lucas studied movie-making and made a number of student films. ⁸Lucas's third feature film, *Star Wars*, changed everything. ⁹A seemingly simple story of good versus evil, *Star Wars* became a huge international hit.¹ ¹⁰The movie used new technologies that revolutionized² the film industry. ¹¹One new technology was a special computer-assisted camera crane.³ ¹²Camera operators filmed most of the space fight scenes from the crane. ¹³Lucas is also responsible for the modern THX sound system, which improves the way a movie sounds in theaters. ¹⁴His latest innovation⁴ is the use of digital

photography in filmmaking. ¹⁵To sum up, George Lucas's love of storytelling and his technological innovations have transformed⁵ movie-making forever.

Questions on the Model

1. In sentence 1, what is the subject? What is the verb? Underline the subject with one line and the verb with two lines.
2. In sentence 7, underline the subject with one line. How many verbs belong to this subject? Underline them with two lines.
3. In the last sentence of the paragraph, underline the verb with two lines. How many subjects are there? Underline them with one line.

¹**hit:** success

²**revolutionized:** completely changed

³**crane:** tall machine used to lift and move objects in the construction of buildings and to load and unload ships

⁴**innovation:** new idea or invention

⁵**transformed:** changed

Simple Sentences

A **sentence** is a group of words that (a) contains at least one subject and one verb and (b) expresses a complete thought.

There are four kinds of sentences in English: **simple sentences**, **compound sentences**, **complex sentences**, and **compound-complex sentences**. First, let's learn about simple sentences.

A **simple sentence** has one subject-verb pair. The subject tells *who* or *what* did something. The verb tells the action (*jump, work, think*) or condition (*is, was, seem, appear*).

s
v
 Filmmaker George Lucas has changed the film industry in many ways.
s
v
 One new technology was a special computer-assisted camera crane.

A simple sentence can have one of several possible “formulas.” Here are four possibilities. The subject(s) in each sentence are underlined with one line. The verb(s) are underlined with two lines.

	Sentence “formula”
1. <u>The Star Wars movies</u> <u>were</u> international hits.	S V
2. <u>Young people and adults</u> <u>enjoyed</u> them.	S S V
3. <u>The films</u> <u>entertained</u> and <u>thrilled</u> audiences everywhere.	S V V
4. <u>Luke Skywalker and his friends</u> <u>battled</u> evil and <u>made</u> us laugh at the same time.	S S V V

Notice that the subject in a simple sentence may have two or more items (sentences 2 and 4). The verb may have two or more items (sentences 3 and 4). These are all simple sentences because there is only one subject-verb pair.

Subject-Verb Agreement

You already know that subjects and verbs agree in number.

My sister **is** married. (*singular*)

My sisters **are** married. (*plural*)

My brother and I **are** single. (*plural*)

Subject-verb agreement is sometimes confusing in the following situations.

1. When a sentence begins with the word *there* + the verb *be*, the subject follows the *be* verb. Look ahead to see whether to use a singular or plural verb.

There **is** a **student** in the hall. (*The verb is is singular to agree with a student.*)

There **are** **three students** in the hall. (*The verb are is plural to agree with three students.*)

There **was** **no reason** for his action.

There **were** **many reasons** for his success.

2. A prepositional phrase (a group of words beginning with a preposition such as *of*, *with*, *in*, *at*, or *on* and ending with a noun or pronoun) can come between a subject and its verb. Prepositional phrases may come after a subject, but *they are not part of the subject*. You should mentally cross them out when you are deciding if the verb should be singular or plural.

One (of my sisters) **is** a singer. (*The subject is one, not sisters.*)

The color (of her eyes) **changes** when she is angry. (*The subject is color, not eyes.*)

Six kinds (of rice) **are** available in the grocery store. (*The subject is kinds, not rice.*)

3. Some words are always singular.

One (of my brothers) **is** a musician.

Neither (of my parents) **is** living.

Much (of my time) **is** spent in the library.

Each (of my brothers) **wants** his own car.

Either (of my sisters) **is** able to baby-sit for you tonight.

Nothing ever **happens** in my life.

Is anyone home?

4. A few words are always plural.

Both (of my parents) **are** teachers.

Several (of the teachers) **speak** my language.

Many (of my friends) **work** in the library.

5. A few words can be either singular or plural. In these cases, you must refer to the noun in the prepositional phrase.

Some (of the money) **was** missing. (*singular*)

Some (of the students) **were** missing. (*plural*)

All (of my time) **is** spent in the library. (*singular*)

All (of my brothers) **are** singers. (*plural*)

Most (of the ice) **was** melted. (*singular*)

Most (of the ice cubes) **were** melted. (*plural*)

A lot (of the work) **was** too easy. (*singular*)

A lot (of the people) **were** angry. (*plural*)

None (of the fruit) **is** fresh. (*singular*)

None (of the apples) **are** fresh. (*plural*)

PRACTICE 2**Identifying
Subjects, Verbs,
and Prepositional
Phrases**

Underline the subjects with one line and the verbs with two lines. Put parentheses () around prepositional phrases.

1. My name is Roberto Sanchez.
2. I was born (on September 21, 1978,) (in the city) (of San Juan, Puerto Rico.)
3. I am a student at Greenhills College in Boston, Massachusetts.
4. Some of my classes are difficult.
5. Some of the homework is boring.
6. A lot of my classes are in Dante Hall.
7. A lot of my time is spent in the student lounge.
8. My father works in an office.
9. None of my brothers are married.
10. None of the money was stolen.
11. My youngest brother and sister are still in high school.
12. My father understands English but doesn't speak it.
13. In South America, most of the people are Catholic.
14. Neither of my parents has been to the United States.

PRACTICE 3**Subject-Verb
Agreement**

A. In each sentence, underline the subject with one line and write S above it. Then cross out the incorrect verb form.

1. One ^S of my classmates (is/~~are~~) from my country, El Salvador.
2. Some of the teachers (speak/~~speaks~~) my language.
3. Each of the gifts (was/~~were~~) carefully wrapped in gold paper.
4. One of the words on the test (was/~~were~~) misspelled.
5. A lot of my classes (was/~~were~~) canceled last week.
6. A lot of my time (is/~~are~~) spent in the library.
7. In my country most of the people (want to go/~~wants to go~~) to college.
8. (Do/~~Does~~) anyone know the correct time?
9. There (is/~~are~~) several kinds of flowers in the bouquet.
10. There (wasn't/~~weren't~~) any electricity in our building last night.
11. The noise from the firecrackers (was/~~were~~) loud.

- B. Editing Practice** Find and correct six errors in subject-verb agreement in the following paragraph.

Young Golf Stars

¹Golf is no longer the sport of rich, middle-aged, white men. ²Young people around the world is taking up¹ the game, and some of them is taking it over.² ³One of the young stars are Sergio Garcia, a fascinating young golfer from Spain. ⁴Sergio was born in 1980 and started playing golf at the age of 3. ⁵He became a professional golfer in 1999 at the age of 19. ⁶Sergio became famous by hitting a golf shot at a target from behind a tree with his eyes closed. ⁷Two other young golf stars are Tiger Woods and Michelle Wie. ⁸Both Tiger and Michelle started playing golf at very young ages, and both has ethnic backgrounds. ⁹Tiger, born in California in 1975, is Thai-African-American-Native-American. ¹⁰Michelle, born in Hawaii in 1989, is Korean-American. ¹¹Each of these two young Americans have shocked the world of golf in different ways. ¹²Tiger shocked everyone by becoming the best golfer in the world while still in his early twenties. ¹³Michelle shocked everyone by competing against men—and beating many of them—at the age of fourteen. ¹⁴It is clear that all three of these young golfers has great futures ahead of them.

Fragments

In some languages, you can sometimes leave out the subject in a sentence; in others, you can sometimes leave out the verb. In English, you must ALWAYS have at least one subject and one verb in every sentence.³ If you leave out either the subject or the verb, your sentence is incomplete. We call an incomplete sentence a **fragment**.

These are fragments. Fragments are sentence errors.

1. Is not easy to get an A in Professor Wilson's class. (*There is no subject.*)
2. People in New York always in a hurry. (*There is no verb.*)

To correct Sentence 1, add a subject:

It is not easy to get an A in Professor Wilson's class.

To correct Sentence 2, add a verb:

People in New York **are** always in a hurry.

¹taking up: learning

²taking it over: taking control over it

³There is one exception to this rule. In commands such as *Stop that!* and *Listen carefully*, the subject *you* is not expressed.

PRACTICE 4**Fragments**

- A. Step 1** Read each sentence and decide if it is a complete sentence or a fragment. Mark the fragments with an *X* to show that it is incorrect.
- Step 2** Decide what is wrong with each fragment. Is the verb missing? Is the subject missing?

Step 3 Correct each fragment by adding a subject or a verb.

It is

- X 1. ~~Is~~ very hot today even with the windows open.
2. Jose and Jin the smartest students in the class.
3. They study all the time.
4. The baby finally sleepy.
5. She is closing her eyes.
6. Ms. Woodbury, our grammar teacher, often late on Fridays.
7. Is important for students to get to class on time.

- B. Editing Practice** Find and underline five fragments in the following paragraph. Then correct each one.

My Best Friend

My best friend is Suzanne. We have been friends since childhood. As children we lived next door to each other in Caracas. Now live in different countries on different continents. She is married to a Venezuelan. Has three children. Her son two years old, and her twin daughters three months old. We haven't seen each other for eight years. We keep in touch by e-mail. Also telephone each other at least once a month. We will be friends forever.

The Writing Process

Overview

Writing is never a one-step action; it is an ongoing creative act. When you first write something, you have already been thinking about what to say and how to say it. Then after you have finished writing, you read over what you have written and make changes and corrections. You write and revise and write and revise again until you are satisfied that your writing expresses exactly what you want to say.

The process of writing has roughly four steps. In the first step, you create ideas. In the second step, you organize the ideas. In the third step, you write a rough draft. In the final step, you polish your rough draft by editing it and making revisions.